Push

By Sapphire

INTRODUCTION

A black street girl, sixteen years old and pregnant, again, with her father's child, speaks. In a voice that shakes us by its language, its story, and its unflinching honesty, Precious Jones records her journey up from Harlem's lowest depths. . . For Precious, miraculously, hope appears and the world begins to open up when a courageous black teacher bullies, cajoles, and inspires her to learn to read, to define her own feelings and set them down in a diary: to discover the truth of her life.

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PRECIOUS: When I get to school early sometimes I just sit in front part on the black plastic couch that need tape where it cut and the yellow foam pads show through. School start at 9 o'clock. The secretary get here at 8:00 a.m. I don' get here before that' cause the door locked and I would have to wait in the lobby downstairs. Which I don't like.

Our room is nice. Nicer since we have one day where we come in "raggedy" and bring our own cleaning stuff'n posters, pictures, 'n plants from home 'n fix up our room. Ms Rain say bring something of YOU! I bring picture of Abdul and plant from Woolworth on 125th Street. It growed. Leaves big. Ms Rain done changed its pot three times.

Ms Rain get here 'bout 8: 15 or so, usually right behind or in front of Rita or Rhonda. They bofe erly birds too. Ms Rain jus' give whoever here the keys from her purse to open up our classroom while she do whatever she do-fix coffee, git books from supply room-stuff like that. By 8:30 a.m. early birds good to go! Room quiet sunny. We just open our notebook, Ms Rain usually say something like, You got 10 or 15 minutes 'fore the "rabble" get here. Yeah, I don't know exactly what is the rabble. She jus' joking for Jermaine and them who hit the door roun' 9:05 a.m. Always a little late, always complaining 'bout something-the weather, train, what the newspaper say.

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Me, I, just look at the sun coming in through the front window. Pretty soon it move around and come in through the side window. I like the routine of school, the dream of school. I wonder where I be if I had been learning all those years I sit at LS. 146. Favorite book? Maybe it's our book, the big book with all our stories in it. Not mine yet. I'm just putting stuff in my journal now.

Telling time is easy. Fractions, percents, multiplying, dividing is EASY. Why no one never taught me these things before. Rita say, All people with HIV or AIDS is innocent victims; it's a disease, not a "good," a "bad." You know what she mean? Well, thas good' cause I don't. I cannot see how I am the same as a crack addict. Rita kiss my forehead, hold each my cheeks with her hands, look me in my eyes, "Negra," she say, her eyes big like babies', black black eyes. ''You don't see now but will. You will."

I don't know how I will, I don't even know what she's talkin' about. She's talking about Life, Ms Rain say. Well, I don't know what life is all about either. I know I'm eighteen, magic number. And my reading score is 2.8. I ask Ms Rain what that mean. She say it's a number! And can't no numbers measure how far I done come in jus' two years. She say forget about the numbers and just keep working. The author has a message and the reader's job is to decode that message as thoroughly as possible. A good reader is like a detective, she say, looking for clues in the text. A good reader is like you Precious, she say. Passionate! Passionately involved with whut they are reading. Don't worry about numbers and fill in the blank, just read and write!

I'm changing. Things I don't care about no more: if boyz love me, extensions, new closes what I care about is: STAYING HEALTHY, sex, notebook, writing poems

Ms Rain say don't always rhyme, stretch for words to fall like drops of rain, snowflakes-did you know no two snowflakes is alike? Have you ever seen a snowflake? I haven't! All I seen is gobs of dirty gray shit. You mean to tell me that nasty stuff is made of snowy flakes. I don't believe it.

Each day is different. All the days is gobbed together to make a year, all the years gobbed together to make a life. I have a secret. Secret is, I mean I think Rita and Ms Rain halfway know

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but they too nice to get any further in my business than I want them in. I mean I have kids. But I never have a guy, you know like that. It never usta be on my mind. All I want before is Daddy to leave me alone! But now I think about that, you know, that being a cute boy. I think about that and I think about being a poet or rapper or an artist even. It's this guy on one-two-five, Franco, he done painted pictures on the steel gates that's over almos' all the store windows. At night you walk down and each one is painted different. I like that better than museum.

It's so many different ways to walk the few blocks home. Turn a corner and you see all different. Pass 116th 'n Lenox, more abandoned land, buildings falling down. How it git so ugly is people throw trash all in it. City don't pick it up; dogs doo doo. Ugliness grow multiplied by ten. Keep walkin' down Lenox to one-twelve you pass projects. I never did live in projects. I live in 444 Lenox Avenue almost all my life. Where I live before that house I don't know, maybe wif my grandmother.

I got session wif counselor today. Last week we try to figure out how long I been infected. People at retard place say Lil Mongo don't got it. She say that could mean Daddy get AIDS pretty fast from time he first infected to time he die? 'Cause if Lil Mongo don't got it maybe he didn't have it 1983 when she born. Then after she born he go away a long time. So maybe I get it eighty-six, eighty-seven? Counselor say, I'm on top now. I'm young, is got no disease and stuff, not no drug addict. I could live a long time, she say. I ask her what's a long time. She don't say.

I think some of the girls at Advancement House know I am . . . am positive. I mean wifout trying I know some of they bizness. They never was too friendly; since Mama come wif her news, they even less friendly. But who cares? I'm not tight wif these girls in the house. They got problems, come in room and steal. I know I ain' the only one that got it, even though that's how it feels. But I'm probably the only one get it from they daddy. Counselor, Ms Weiss, say she try to find out as much about Daddy for me as she can.

How much I want to know? And for what? I tell counselor I can't talk about Daddy now. Daddy sick me, disgust me, but still did that to me. I nawshus in my stomach and I think I want it back,

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the smell of the bedroom, the hurt-he slap my face till it sting and my ears sing separate songs from each other, call me names.

I wait for him get off me. Lay there stare at wall till wall is a movie, Wizard of Oz, I can make that one play anytime. Michael Jackson, scarecrow.

Afterward I go bafroom. If I go to insect support group what will I hear from other girls. I bite my fingernails till they look like disease, pull strips of my skin away. Get Daddy's razor out cabinet. Cut cut cut arm wrist, not trying to die, trying to plug myself back in. I am a TV set wif no picture. I am broke wif no mind. No past or present time. Only the movies of being someone else. Someone not fat, dark skin, short hair. A pink virgin girl. A girl like Janet Jackson, a sexy girl. A girl for value.

I hate myself when I think of Daddy. Hate wif a capital letter. Counselor say, "Memories." How is something a memory if you never forgit? But I push it to the corner of my brain.

I exhausted, I mean wipe out! What kinda chile gotta think about a daddy like I do? But I'm not a chile. I'm a mother of a chile myself!

In school we had to memorize a poem like the rappers do. And say it in front the class. Everybody do real short poems except me and Jermaine. She do poem by lady name Pat Parker. I get up to do my poem, it's by Langston Hughes, I dedicate it to Abdul. Introduce myself to the class (even though everybody know me). I say my name is Precious Jones and this poem is for my baby son, Abdul Jamal Louis Jones. Then I let loose:

MOTHER TO SON

Well, son, I'll tell you:
Life for me ain't been no crystal stair. It's had tacks in it,
And splinters,
And boards tom up,
And places with no carpet on the floorBare.
But all the time
I'se been a-climbin' on,
And reach in' landin's,
Ana tumin' comers,

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And sometimes goin' in the dark Where there ain't been no light.
So boy, don't you turn back.
Don't you set down on the steps
'Cause you finds it's kinder hard. Don't you fall now
For I'se still go in', honey,
I'se still climbin',
And life for me ain't been no crystal stair.

And after I finish everyone goin', Yeah! Yeah! Shoutin', Go Precious! And clapping and clapping and clapping. I felt very good.

Ms Rain say write our fantasy of ourselves. How we would be if life was perfect. I tell you one thing right now, I would be light skinned, thereby treated right and loved by boyz. Light even more important than being skinny, you see them light-skinned girls that's big an' fat, they got boyfriends. Boyz overlook a lot to be wif a white girl or yellow girl, especially if it's a boy that's dark skin wif big lips or nose, he will go APE over yellow girl. So that's my first fantasy, is get light. Then I get hair. Swing job, you know like I do with my extensions, but this time it be my own hair, permanently.

Then, this part is hard to say, because so much of my heart is love for Abdul. But I be a girl or woman-yeah girl, 'cause I would still be a girl now if I hadn't had no kids. I would be a virgin like Madonna. I would be a different Precious Jones.

So there if I have a fantasy it be how I look. Ms Rain say I am beautiful like I am. Where? How? To who? To not have no kids mean I woulda had a different life. Counselor ask me one time is it the kids or is it I get raped to have' em. Bofe; 'cause even if I not raped, who want a baby at twelve! Thas how old I was when I had Little Mongo.

What is a normal life? A life where you not 'shamed of your mother. Where yur friends come over after school and watch TV and do homework.

Where yur mother is normal looking and don't hit you over the head wif iron skillet. I would wish for in my fantasy a second chance. Since my first chance go to Mama and Daddy.

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Ms Rain always saying write remember write remember. Counselor say talk about it, talk about it-the PAST. What about NOW! At least wif school I am getting' ready for my future (which to me is right now).

I don't know why I don't like counselor but Ms Rain say TALK, it gonna make things better whether I like her or not. But you know she jus' another social worker scratching on a pad. I know she writing reports on me. Reports go in file. File say what I could get, where I could go-if I could get cut off, kicked out Advancement House. Make me feel like Mama.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2017 National Qualifier
KS State Qualifier

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